

A FREE GUIDE FOR FUTURE AUTHORS

10 Questions to Clarify the Book You Were Born to Write

Thinking about writing a book? Start here. This guide walks you through the ten questions every serious author answers before writing a single chapter.

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Before You Write a Single Chapter

You have a book inside you. You have known it for a while. Maybe it comes from your career, your faith, your business, or a hard season you came through with lessons worth sharing. So what is stopping you? For most future authors, it is not talent and it is not time. It is clarity.

This guide is for the professional, entrepreneur, or thought leader who is serious about writing a nonfiction book but has not yet put the foundation in place. Here is the win you will walk away with: by the time you answer all ten questions, you will know exactly what your book is about, who it serves, and why you are the one to write it. That clarity is what separates authors who finish from writers who stall at chapter three.

How to use it: work through the questions in order. Write your answers in the spaces provided, by hand or in a notes file. Do not skip the hard ones. The questions that make you pause are the ones doing the most work. Come on, let's create a strong foundation together.

PRO TIP: Set aside 60 to 90 minutes of uninterrupted time. Answering these questions in one focused sitting produces sharper answers than spreading them across a busy week.

QUESTION 1

Who exactly is your reader?

A book written for everyone reaches no one. Take a moment to think about the one person you are writing to. Not a demographic. A person. What do they do for a living? What keeps them up at night? What have they already tried that did not work?

Imagine a first-time entrepreneur sitting across from you at breakfast, asking for your help. That is your reader. Every chapter you write should feel like your side of that conversation.

Write a two or three sentence description of your one specific reader.

QUESTION 2

What problem does your book solve?

Nonfiction readers do not buy books. They buy solutions. Your reader picks up your book because something in their life or business is not working and they believe you can fix it. So what does this imply? Your book needs one clear problem at its center, stated in the reader's own words.

If you cannot name the problem in one sentence, your reader cannot either, and they will put the book back on the shelf.

State the one problem your book solves, in the words your reader would use.

QUESTION 3

What is your book's one promise?

The promise is the transformation your reader gets if they read the book and do the work. It is the answer to the question every buyer silently asks: what will be different for me when I finish this?

Simply put, a strong promise sounds like this: read this book, apply what it teaches, and you will be able to do a specific thing you cannot do today. One promise. Not five. A book with five promises keeps none of them.

Complete this sentence: After reading my book, my reader will be able to...

QUESTION 4

Why are you the one to write it?

You do not need a PhD or a famous name. You need proximity to the problem and proof you have navigated it. Maybe you solved it in your own life. Maybe you have guided clients through it. Maybe you have studied it longer and deeper than your reader ever will.

This question is not about impressing anyone. It is about identifying the credibility you already carry so you can write with conviction instead of hesitation. Do you remember how many times you fell before you learned what you now know? That is your qualification.

List three experiences, results, or credentials that make you the right guide for this reader.

QUESTION 5

What must your reader believe differently?

Every great nonfiction book changes a belief before it changes a behavior. Your reader is walking in with assumptions, and some of those assumptions are the very thing keeping them stuck.

Take a moment to think about the belief your book must challenge. Maybe your reader believes networking is only for extroverts, or that publishing a book requires a big-name publisher. Name the old belief, then name the new one your book installs in its place.

Write the belief your reader holds now, and the belief they will hold after your book.

QUESTION 6

What is your framework?

Readers remember frameworks, not paragraphs. A framework is your repeatable path from problem to promise: the steps, stages, or principles that organize your teaching. It becomes your table of contents, your talks, and often your coaching offer.

You do not need something fancy. Three to seven steps with plain names will beat a clever acronym that confuses people. If your method is still fuzzy, write down how you would walk one person through the problem, start to finish. That walk is your framework.

Sketch your framework in three to seven steps, one line each.

QUESTION 7

What stories will carry the teaching?

Lessons inform, but stories transform. Every principle in your book needs a story or example that makes it land: a client win, a personal failure, a conversation at an event, a before and after your reader can see themselves in.

Start your inventory now. You will be surprised how many teaching moments you have been collecting for years without realizing they belong in a book.

List five stories or examples from your life or work that could anchor a chapter.

QUESTION 8

Where does this book fit in your bigger mission?

A book is not the finish line. It is a door. For most authors, the book opens doors to speaking, coaching, consulting, community, or the next book. So, what's next for you after someone reads the last page?

When you know where the book fits in your larger work, you write it differently. You build natural bridges from the page to the next step, and the book starts working for you long after launch day.

Describe what you want this book to make possible in your business, ministry, or career.

QUESTION 9

What does success look like?

Every individual in the world is different, and so is every author's definition of a win. For one author, success is a bestseller flag on Amazon. For another, it is fifty new coaching clients, a legacy for their kids, or a message finally out of their head and into the world.

Define it now, before you write, because your definition of success shapes your decisions on length, publishing path, pricing, and promotion. A book without a target hits nothing.

Write your definition of success for this book in one or two sentences, with a number if you can.

QUESTION 10

What has stopped you, and what will you do about it?

Be honest here. Is it time? Fear of judgment? Not knowing where to start? The doubt that whispers someone else already wrote this better? Name it. An obstacle you name is an obstacle you can plan around. An obstacle you ignore will meet you at chapter three.

Embarrassments are normal, don't take them to heart. Every published author you admire faced the same resistance you feel right now. The difference is they moved anyway, one page at a time.

Name your biggest obstacle, then write one specific action you will take this week to move past it.

YOUR ACTION STEP FOR TODAY: Take your answers to questions 1, 2, and 3 and combine them into a single paragraph: who your book is for, the problem it solves, and the promise it makes. That paragraph is your book's foundation statement. Put it somewhere you will see it every time you sit down to write.

About Michael

Michael J.P. Wilson is a published nonfiction author, the CEO of Entrepreneur Power Network, and the founder of Power Reads Publishing and Author's Path. He coaches entrepreneurs, professionals, and thought leaders through the full journey from idea to published book, including how to use AI as a strategic writing partner without losing their voice. He is also an Army veteran and a doctoral student who believes a book is one of the strongest authority assets a leader can build. He created this guide because he has watched too many capable people carry a book in their head for years, and clarity is the fastest cure he knows.

Ready to Turn These Answers Into a Book?

You just did the thinking most aspiring authors never do. Your reader is defined, your promise is clear, and your framework is taking shape. So, what is it that you need to do now? Get a proven path and a guide who has walked it.

That is exactly what Author's Path delivers: a step-by-step program that takes you from the foundation you just built to a finished, published book you are proud to put your name on. The next step is a short conversation about your book, where it stands, and what it will take to finish it.

BOOK YOUR FREE AUTHOR CLARITY CALL: Visit michaeljpwilson.com to schedule a call and walk through your ten answers with Michael. Bring this guide. We will map your fastest route from idea to published author. Are you ready to grab it and step in?